

Guidelines for Praying in Tongues

Look at Luke 16, beginning around verse 19:

There was a certain rich man, which was clothed in purple and fine linen, and fared sumptuously every day:
And there was a certain beggar named Lazarus, which was laid at his gate, full of sores,
And desiring to be fed with the crumbs which fell from the rich man's table: moreover the dogs came and licked his sores.
And it came to pass, that the beggar died, and was carried by the angels into Abraham's bosom: the rich man also died, and was buried.

What part of the rich man was buried? His body. What part of Lazarus was carried into Abraham's bosom? His spirit.

Then verse 23 says:

And in hell he lift up his eyes, being in torments...

If his body was buried, then do not tell me the spirit man does not have eyes. In hell he lifted up his eyes. So we know that people in hell at least have eyes.

It also says he was in torments. So the spirit man has emotions.

He saw Abraham afar off and Lazarus in his bosom, and he cried and said:

Father Abraham, have mercy on me, and send Lazarus, that he may dip the tip of his finger in water, and cool my tongue...

So we know that people in Abraham's bosom, and now in heaven, at least have the tip of a finger. We also know the spirit man has a tongue.

The spirit man has eyes, fingers, and a tongue. Isn't that amazing? I love this stuff.

Actually, my spirit man fits in my body basically cell for cell. If I were to step out of my body and stand here in my spirit man, and you could see both my body and my spirit man, I could hold up this physical finger and ask, "What is this?"

You would say, "That is your finger."

"What is it made of?"

Flesh, blood, bone. Break it down further: cells, compounds, atoms, protons, neutrons, electrons. We could break it down farther, but that is as far as we will go.

Now suppose I hold up the finger of my spirit man and ask, "What is this made of?"

You would say, "That is your spirit, your inner man, the hidden man of the heart."

But what does it break down to? What is the basic unit of my spirit finger? There is no way to know except that it is made out of a substance called spirit. Yet it fits in my hand, not just hand for hand, but cell for cell, right down to a basic operation in creation.

My spirit man has authority in this world because it operates through this physical body. When I lift my arm, my spirit man lifts his arm and moves my physical body. I can see through my eyes, hear through my ears, and function through this physical man, which allows me to operate in this world.

I was with Ronald Coyne and helped tape his eye because he had his eye put out. He did not have an eye. He had a plastic eye. When you held the plastic eye up, you could not see through it. You could hold it up to the light and see light through it, but you could not see anything else through that eye.

I saw it.

He got ready to demonstrate his miracle because he could see. He popped that eye out and held his socket open so you could see to the back of the socket. I was right up there and helped him tape the good physical eye shut. I knew he could not see out of it.

Then he looked at me, got out his driver's license, and started reading the fine print on it. I got right up under him, looking up, and there was nothing in there. No eye. Nothing.

I was thinking, "He can see me." He could read fine print, and he did not have an eye.

Then the bigger miracle to me was that he took that eye, which was not transparent, popped it back in, and could still see. You could put your hand over it and block his vision. But he could take that artificial eye, pop it in there, and still see through it.

What God did was a miracle in reverse. He opened that eye in the spirit so he could see in the natural world.

I know people with no eardrums who hear. God did the same thing.

But what would be a real miracle is if a man with his legs cut off came walking in and moving around, and there was nothing there. You would say, "All right, I want to get saved. I am either going to get saved or go crazy."

You also have a spiritual brain, a spirit brain. Some of you ought to show a little more sense in the spirit realm. He is sensible; sometimes you are not operating out of him when you think you are.

Your spiritual brain fits inside your natural brain, and he functions through that.

We could go deeper into the connection between the soul, emotions, and bio-programming, which simulates emotions by chemical reaction. That is all an animal has: emotions based on chemical reaction. Animals do not have a spirit that those emotions manifest through.

We can go as deep into that as you want, because the Holy Ghost took me and taught me all that in prayer. He taught me how to operate in the spirit.

Science has isolated part of this as the subconscious mind. They know it has much more ability than the conscious mind, and they have never been able to explore its limitations. It does not seem to have any. Created in God's class, it does not seem to forget.

The spirit mind has a lot more ability. It also happens to be the part of you the Holy Spirit communicates with.

Someone says, "Brother Roberson, it feels like He speaks here, in my heart."

When I first saw men operate in the word of knowledge, I wanted it so badly. I think now it was because it was part of my calling, though I did not know it. I would pester them until three in the morning.

"Tell me again, how did you hear God?"

"He spoke to my spirit."

"Could you please get a little more specific?"

"He spoke to my spirit."

"I know that, because I know you heard Him and what you said was right. But how did He speak to your spirit?"

They did not really know how. They just knew when He did because they had gotten to know Him. They would say, "It comes way down deep from my spirit. It comes up from deep within."

So I would ask, "Could you isolate the approximate region? Does it start just above the belly button, or a little lower, and come up?"

It does seem that way. But because your physical brain houses your spiritual brain, your spiritual mind seems to be recessed much deeper than the physical level of operation. It seems to come from the center of your being. But the mind of your spirit is not down in your belly. There is no use in God dealing with your belly.

The belly is the center of your being, a power source. But He talks to your spirit. It seems deep because it is a deeper level than the physical mind.

This is where the baptism of the Holy Spirit basically took place. Of course, He is wall to wall. He has filled you up. But the mind of the Holy Spirit operates within your spiritual mind. He does not operate somewhere else. He does not speak to you in one place one time and another place

another time, excluding the physical operation when God steps outside of everything and talks to you from the outside.

Sometimes He has to say, "Hello, you little carnal flesh creature who cannot be led. Sit down for a minute."

I think I have heard His voice from the outside only one time in my life. I was sitting on the steps, and somebody called my name three times. I turned around behind me to see if someone had said something. Nobody had.

I had no sooner settled down than He called again. He did that three times. The third time He said, "David."

I turned around again, and nobody was there talking to me. Then when I turned back around, He changed and started talking to my spirit. He told me some things that would happen in my future. They have not happened yet, but I can just about guarantee where they will begin happening. It will be here.

He does not like to talk to your outer ear. When He communicates with your spirit, there is only one place He communicates.

Most of you come under an anointing, so you have no trouble knowing it is Him. You come under an anointing, He begins to talk, and you know it is Him because you are under that anointing.

One day I prayed an extended amount of time in the Holy Ghost. I slipped into the spirit and had one of those inner visions. I saw my physical man in front of me, constituted by a dark form. Then my soul seemed to come online next, because there was some light in my body, though not very much.

Then came the spirit man, which fit inside all of it and was very bright, much brighter. The brain part, the center of the mind, was very bright. The bright area was where the Holy Spirit operated.

That is when He taught me the first steps to knowing and listening for His voice. As I watched, I saw the Holy Spirit create and operate out of that place somewhere in the spirit man's mind. It seemed to be back here somewhere.

He had me do this. He said, "Pray in tongues."

So I started praying in tongues. Then a strong impulse came to stop. The moment I shut my mouth, the words did not come out of my mouth. They floated up to my mind, to the physical part of my mind.

When I shut my tongue down, the words kept coming. I stopped for a minute and listened, and I could actually hear those words of tongues being created, coming into existence, and rising to my mind.

That is when He spoke to me and said, "Welcome to My voice."

The same place where I create the words of tongues is also where I capsule a whole revelation. It is like downloading a computer chip with a whole revelation: a mystery on healing, a mystery on righteousness, a mystery of understanding. When He is done downloading it in that language, He sends it across to your spirit and releases the whole revelation at once.

Suddenly you understand a whole revelation in a millisecond. A moment ago you did not understand it. Suddenly the whole thing dawns on you. Sometimes it takes me a month to preach what I received in a millisecond.

When you pray in tongues, He creates those tongues in the same place. Most of the time you do not hear them because the way you are created is that the moment they are created, they seize hold of your tongue. Your tongue forms the linguistics for the word created in your spirit.

If it comes out of your mouth, it does not come up to your mind. It is diverted through a gate that takes it right out. If you shut your mouth, it will come up to your mind, though not for very long. What activates the flow is when your tongue lets it out that gate.

It is like a siphon. It will keep bringing one sentence after another. But if you shut your mouth, eventually it will stop. Not only will it stop, but you will have to force yourself to keep trying to pray silently in the spirit. The words will float up to your mind. If you are forcing yourself to do that with your mind, then your mind cannot do anything else because the words of tongues occupy it.

The same place where He spoke tongues in my spirit is the place I hear Him if I stop and the words come up to my mind. They seem to come from down here somewhere, but actually they come forward and I hear them.

I have isolated that place through many hours of prayer. I have isolated the ear of the spirit, if you will allow me to say it that way. He can stop the tongues and start speaking English. God can stop me, my mind quiets down, and my physical mind opens up to the spirit. When it does, I know He is ready to talk to me.

He will start talking in English, but the English comes into existence in the same place. I know it is Him because I have become familiar with that place from hundreds of hours of tongues coming from the same place. I know the difference between that voice and mental energy when I am thinking about something.

A question arises: Is praying in tongues silently, just inside, not moving my tongue, effective?

Even though there is no ironclad Scripture against it, all the other Scriptures that mention praying in tongues or speaking with tongues connect utterance with it.

I have found that when I lock my tongue up, the flow stops. The tongue seems to finish the sequence.

It does not matter when I pray quietly. After I about exhausted my vocal cords, I decided to give that a try. Besides, I got tired of people turning me in at motel rooms and beating on the walls.

So I started praying without using my vocal cords. But it still finished the circuit. The tongue connected to that language was able to deliver the sequence. Then came the next phrase, and the next phrase.

If I stop my tongue, I have to concentrate with mental energy. Faith and the Holy Spirit activate the language in me, but if it is not allowed to finish the sequence, because the tongue is connected to it, it generally stops. I have to exert a lot of mental energy to keep it going. Therefore, I cannot use my mind for anything else because it floats up into my mind and occupies it.

So no, I do not think trying to pray in tongues only in your mind and heart, without finishing the sequence, is effective. That is why Scripture connects utterance with it.

Look at 1 Corinthians 14:14:

For if I pray in an unknown tongue, my spirit prayeth, but my understanding is unfruitful.

Whose spirit is doing the praying? My spirit. Would you go as far as to say my human spirit? If I pray in an unknown tongue, my human spirit prays.

There has to be a transference of that language from the Holy Spirit to your spirit. That transference is made at the moment of creation. Praying in tongues is as supernatural as raising the dead. The Holy Spirit literally creates that language on the inside of your spirit. At the point of creating it, He transfers it to your spirit.

Paul says that when this same man prays in an unknown tongue, he speaks not unto men because it is not a language to be interpreted for the edifying of the Body. It is for his own edification. It is for the mysteries to be understood by him, mysteries he is praying and will eventually understand when he finishes praying them out.

When I, Dave Roberson, pray in an unknown tongue, it is my spirit praying. My understanding is unfruitful. During those hours in prayer, most of the time my mind does not understand the vowels and syllables I am speaking. I have no idea what I am saying, sometimes for five or six hours of prayer.

Sometimes He begins a translation process while I am praying, and the mystery is being translated in my mind. Then my mind performs one function while my spirit does another. My spirit receives the language, and my mind receives the translation of it. I do not always know word for word, but mysteries begin to unfold to me one after another when my Teacher kicks in.

I am glad my mind is unfruitful when I spend six hours in prayer, because I found out I can employ my mind to take in the Word of God while my spirit is praying.

I will sit here, and now it is so automatic that when I pick up my Bible, I begin to read:

In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.

I will pick it up and start reading.

One of my favorite things is to take Galatians, Ephesians, and Philippians and read those books over and over while I am praying in tongues. Maybe eight times, ten times, twenty times, maybe eight hours.

One of my favorite methods is to walk back and forth. I may sit in a chair and pray an hour or two. I may lie on the floor. Then I will get to walking and praying. My Bible will be somewhere where I can go over and look at it.

In one setting, I will read Ephesians all the way through. Then I will go pray for a while. Then I will walk back and read the whole thing through again. Then I will go back and read the whole thing through again.

I am glad that two parts of me can take in from God at the same time.

Then the Holy Spirit takes all I have meditated into my mind through accumulated knowledge and uses it for the day-and-night meditation process. This is where much of our revelation knowledge comes from.

Paul said, "My spirit prayeth." At that point my understanding is unfruitful.

If I am in church, I need to pray that I may interpret. I ask God for interpretation. But when He transfers the prayer to my spirit, I am not speaking to men. I am talking to God.

Why does the Holy Spirit transfer this language to my spirit if I am talking to the other members of the Godhead? Because this language is designed personally for you. There is nothing closer to your life than this language. You cannot get any closer.

It is the mind of God planned for you all the way through Romans 8. He that searches the heart knows the mind of God and successfully makes intercession for you according to the will of God. Then we know all things work together for good to them that love God and are called according to His purpose because He is working that plan.

Then Paul proves it by saying those He foreknew before the Cross, He predestined. He is showing you God's whole plan from one end to the other and saying the Holy Spirit is involved in it. He knows the plan of God for you.

In order for you to be the one praying with authority, the Holy Spirit gives the language to you. Jesus said, "All authority in heaven is given to Me. Therefore you go." In that statement was a transference of authority.

The Holy Spirit transfers the language to your spirit. Now it is you praying. You are praying out of your authority to the other two members of the Godhead.

I might say you are praying something of a perfect prayer, especially if you keep it up for six hours. Surely one member of the Godhead creating the perfect prayer and the others answering it is a good place to be. You are sandwiched between the Godhead: the Holy Spirit creating the prayer,

you praying it, and the other two members receiving and answering it.

If I pray in an unknown tongue, my human spirit is actually doing the praying because He has transferred that language to my spirit and creates it on the inside.

At the moment He creates it, your tongue shapes it. It is spontaneous. One is not without the other. To shackle your tongue stops the process.

When I whisper in tongues, it is automatic. I start reading and praying. Sometimes it is so automatic that I start reading something in public, such as an airplane magazine, and I pray under my breath. Nobody can hear me usually. Sometimes I lock my jaw and teeth, but my tongue is free in my mouth. It seems to need that much to finish the sequence and keep the siphon flowing.

Look at 1 Corinthians 14:18-19. This is Paul talking, and you might as well know that Paul earned the illustrious reputation among the other apostles of having more revelation knowledge and more foundation. He had their respect.

Let me give you one of his keys. When he was a Pharisee of the Pharisees, he began memorizing the Old Covenant for seven hours a day, beginning at the age of three. Seven hours a day he memorized the Old Covenant.

That was one ingredient.

After he was filled with the Holy Ghost, it is obvious he prayed in tongues more than anyone, probably on the backside of the desert and wherever he was. Since then, I found out that this was a major source of revelation knowledge because of all the mysteries he prayed.

He brought the Old Covenant together with the New. As far as I can see, he was about the only one of the apostles who thoroughly understood the relationship between the Law, our Covenant, and the law of the Spirit of life. That revelation was almost unheard of. It is commonplace to you now, but suppose there was nowhere to go get it.

His revelation knowledge was equivalent in detail to Moses receiving the measurements and facets of the tabernacle, the Law, and those things.

Paul said:

I thank my God, I speak with tongues more than ye all:

Yet in the church I had rather speak five words with my understanding, that by my voice I might teach others also, than ten thousand words in an unknown tongue.

Paul was teaching divine order in church because they were misusing tongues. He said he spoke with tongues, or in the supernatural language that encompasses the mysteries of God, more than them all.

But in church, where we have a meeting with the learned, unlearned, believers, and the lost, and where evangelism goes on, he would rather speak five words with his understanding, that by his voice he might teach others also, than ten thousand words in the unknown tongue.

If I were going to underline anything, I would underline "also." He said, "that I might teach others also." That means he had to be taught first. The subject was tongues.

In these verses you see two things: Paul's private prayer life and how that operation benefited the church.

In his private prayer life, he said, "I thank my God that I pray in tongues more than all of you." But in church, he said, "I would rather speak five words in the language we communicate in so others may understand also than ten thousand words in an unknown tongue."

He was saying, "From praying in the Holy Ghost, I received the revelation. I became edified. I understand the revelation. But if you are going to understand it also, I cannot stand here and communicate it to you in tongues. I must translate that mystery into English so you may also understand the revelation I received."

That is the operation of tongues in church for the teacher: to give you the mystery he received outside of church.

God opened that verse to me in a funny way. I had been praying and kept looking at it, saying, "There is something here I am not getting."

He spoke one statement: "Time it."

How long would it take you to pray ten thousand words in tongues? Time it.

So I did. I did it like a jogger checking a pulse. I prayed at an average rate, like I always do, and basically counted the words. I found out that ten thousand words is roughly an hour and a half.

What Paul was doing was taking the length of a service, about an hour and a half, and saying, "It would not do me any good to stand here for the length of the service and speak in tongues. But if I speak in the language we communicate in, the mystery I received, then you will also understand the mystery I received."

In 1 Corinthians 14:27, Paul is still talking about excelling to a place where the church is edified by your operation of tongues and prophecy:

If any man speak in an unknown tongue, let it be by two, or at the most by three, and that by course; and let one interpret.

But if there be no interpreter, let him keep silence in the church; and let him speak to himself, and to God.

If there is no interpreter, do not speak the tongues out publicly. We are talking about a public assembly with the unlearned and sinners present.

This prayer meeting is a different kind of assembly. You come here knowing this is a prayer meeting. You come knowing we are going to pray in tongues. There is also teaching going on here. This is not the same as a public service where people come in, hardly know each other, and sit down in chairs.

In the public assembly, if interpreters are present, let the tongues be spoken by course and interpreted. But if there is no interpreter, let the person keep silent as far as speaking out publicly. Let him speak to himself and to God.

That means he is speaking in a very low tone. He himself can hear, and he is completing the circuit. Simultaneously with the creation of that language in his spirit, his tongue forms the language. When he speaks it out, it releases it, and the Spirit forms the next sentence, and the next, and the next.

If you stop your tongue, you have taken half the sequence away. That is why Paul said, "Let him speak to himself and to God."

He that prays in an unknown tongue speaks not unto men, but unto God. His spirit has entered into divine communication with God, and he is speaking this language to himself under his breath. Nobody else around him needs to hear it.

Then came teachings about warring tongues. "You have to do that warring tongue."

All of that is very fine if what you mean is adding your authority and emphasis to what He is doing. But you will not do that for ten hours. You will not have any tonsils left.

A lot of times people come in strong, and after eight or nine hours they look like the rest of you.

You can add your authority to what He is doing by emphasis if you want. But what are you warring?

"I am warring against the devil."

Really? I thought Scripture said you were talking to God.

He that speaketh in an unknown tongue speaketh not unto men, but unto God.

"Yes, but I am talking to the devil."

No, you are not.

God took that prayer language away from your mind because you are so prone to mess it up. He leaves your mind out because you do not know who you should be talking to or what you should be praying. That is why He can take a failure and make a success out of him. If you let Him pray long enough, eventually He will get through to you.

I think, to be quite honest, that is about the only chance unusual people have. They operate on another plane. They may not mean to, but their left foot is always out front. While the other salmon are going upstream, they are going downstream saying, "I did not notice."

They are always doing something out of the flow of the Holy Spirit.

I say this with deep-seated concern. If I can find one person God was not sufficient for, one person He could not bring out, then I cannot go as far as I want. But I have never found one He could not bring out if that person would do what He says.

Eventually He will get through to you. That is one reason He took the language away from your mind. He knows what you need desperately, much more than you do. We form our prayers according to our own reasoning and what we think we need. He was with God from the beginning. He saw Him plan your life. He knows what is better for you.

That is why He can promise edification when He prays. But when you get in there with your own understanding, sometimes He cannot promise you much.

I have seen people and wondered, "Is there any hope?" Then I have seen them come online after a year or two of praying, maybe three.

You walk up to them, and they begin talking about the things of the Spirit with balance. What they used to think was God they now recognize was the devil. Weird things have fallen off.

I think, "There is a God in heaven. This is greater than the Red Sea. Anybody can part water. But if God could have simply gotten Adam saved, He would have dusted him off, slammed him down, and said, 'Do not ever do that again.'"

But He could not. He had to take four thousand years and carefully undo what had been done. God is not the kind of sovereign who does as He pleases and slaps you around.

It is harder than parting the Red Sea to deal with somebody's nature.

I have seen the Holy Ghost change people.

When I was a habitual liar, it followed me across the born-again line. At first my conscience was seared by the fact that I wanted to be greater in people's eyes than I was. I could fix that quickly: just tell them a lie and make myself great.

But when you start praying in the Holy Ghost enough, pretty soon He starts dealing with that. It hurts so badly you just want to lie down and die. You cannot get by with it. He follows you around and hounds you.

You have one choice: stop praying and keep lying, or stop lying and keep praying. The two will not live together.

So you are in for some exciting times. Many of you will want to jump up and leave over an emotional fit. That will be the stronghold trying to take you out before you get past it, so you spend the rest of your life floundering.

Let me give one last statement about prayer.

In the lineup of the eight operations of God, the calling begins with apostle, prophet, teacher, workings of miracles, gifts of healings, helps, governments, and finally the prayer ministries of diversities of tongues, beginning with edification and moving into the other supernatural diversities.

Did you notice that apostle, prophet, and teacher are listed before workings of miracles? As the gifts are listed, they are in divine order and in the order of necessity.

The teaching gift takes priority over workings of miracles and gifts of healings. The reason is that the teaching gift is supposed to teach by example. A teaching gift is not really qualified unless it not only has the workings of miracles but is also able to teach the understanding of those miracles from having them.

You do not get into a double-yoked airplane for your solo flight, have the plane go into a nosedive, and yell to the instructor, "Take the yoke," only for him to say, "My God, I do not fly this thing. I just teach on it."

You are going down.

I sure appreciate it if the person teaching me about miracles has worked in them.

There is a priority there. Teacher is supposed to encompass workings of miracles, to be empowered by them, and then on to prophet and apostle.

This is why the devil hates the prayer center.

For years I made this journey alone, trying to exhort people to go. I would go back to a church, and nobody was left. Of the two hundred we excited into prayer, maybe three or four remained. I would go back the next year and excite four hundred more. Nobody would be left the next year.

So God commissioned me to stop here. He said, "You have taken other people's sheep as far as you can. You are ready to learn some things. I want you to take some people into this."

I understand what He is doing.

I could go by myself. Whenever God sees fit, we could come into something. In visions I have seen buildings and things. I do not like to get into that often, but I have seen houses and Holy Spirit winds tipping the whole crowd into miracles and salvation. Then I could pack my bags and go home.

That is one thing, because I am not there as the teacher to both do that and teach you.

The devil knows that if he does not get rid of the prayer center soon, we might be multiplied. There might be a thousand of us.

If God sees fit, if it is a type of mantle like we talked about, the glory could pour out and ten thousand could be saved. But with the teaching gift, I understand the mysteries. There is a chance a thousand of you will be out in different cities across the nation.

He is not just trying to kill me. He is trying to kill you.

Workings of miracles are wonderful. I can pack my bag and go. But the teaching gift means the same thing can be transferred into you. There can be a multiplication table. That spells trouble for the devil.

The devil would like it much better if we only went somewhere, worked miracles, packed the bag, got quiet, and went home. He hates it when you stand up and say, "Do this. Do this. Do this."

Then he has to go to his whole war machine, with many low-level devils and a lot of energy, to corral you and bring you back under control. The more anointed we get, the worse it gets for him. The more we mess him up.

If I were you, I would feast my eyes mostly on the Bible while praying in tongues. Enjoy yourself. Spend the whole day on a book.

Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, and Colossians are books I like to read over and over because they all say almost the same thing. Take one of them and say, "I am going to give my day to this one." Then take another one, and another one.

Pretty soon chapters begin to come together: a chapter over here, a chapter over there, a chapter over here.

Did you know the second chapter of Ephesians says the same thing as 2 Corinthians 5? Ephesians talks about abolishing the enmity in the flesh, tearing down the middle wall of partition, and making of the two one new man. It says there is neither Jew nor Greek.

Second Corinthians 5 says:

If any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new.

It also says:

Henceforth know we no man after the flesh...

It means there is no more knowing a man through his flesh, bloodline, heritage, Jew, Greek, or Scythian. God abolished the enmity and the partition and made of all nations one new man in the new creation of Christ Jesus.

You will not pick those things up until you have thoroughly deposited the book of Ephesians. Then when you are over in another passage, you say, "Where have I heard this before?"

Stand up, and let us worship Him in another song.